



THE VOICE EXPRESS

The Truth Takes Time.

THE VOICE EXPRESS GAZETTE

MEDIA

“He was the Personification of Bravery”: Lauded National Journalist Deepankar Ghose Remembers Mukesh Chandrakar, Criticises Treatment of Regional Reporters

Dipankar Ghose, Deputy National Editor at Hindustan Times, remembers his friend Mukesh Chandrakar — the Bastar-based journalist found dead in a septic tank at the property of a contractor he had exposed — in an 18-part eulogy on X that speaks to the unequal risks borne by regional and independent reporters in India.

BY DIPANKAR GHOSE

7 JANUARY 2025 · 5 MIN READ



ABOUT

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

EDITOR IN CHIEF

Mouli

WEB DEVELOPER

Mitali (Aayat Mahnoor)

CONTACT

thevoiceexpress@proton.me

WEBSITE

<https://thevoiceexpress.in>

LOCATION

New Delhi, India

INDEPENDENT • VOLUNTEER-RUN

VOL. 18 • EST. 2022

© 2026

Following is Hindustan Times' Deputy National Editor, Dipankar Ghose's 18 part eulogy^[1] on X for Bastar based journalist, Mukesh Chandrakar, who was found dead in a septic tank at the property of a construction contractor he had earlier exposed for corruption. Ghose highlights the disproportionate risks faced by regional & independent journalists in India.

5th January 2025: How do you begin to write a tribute to a journalist, a friend, a brother? How do you describe him when nothing really contains him? The first time I met Mukesh Chandrakar was in December 2015, weeks after I had landed in Chhattisgarh as the Indian Express reporter there.

There was a story in Bastar, and I had reached Bijapur, one of India's most dangerous places to report, with very little to go on. There I was, at the district headquarters, in a run-down press club building among a group of journalists eyeing me suspiciously.

The suspicion of "national journalists" is warranted. Very often, we climb on the shoulders of our regional colleagues, leave them to danger, or worse forget we know them. The story spot was deep inside the forests, some 80 kilometres away.

I asked loudly, sheepishly, if someone would come with me tomorrow. By come with me, I meant take me. In that moment, I was helpless. There was only one voice that said "Haan, kal challenge aapke saath."

I went back to the relative comfort of my hotel in Jagdalpur. Mukesh went to the mechanic shop to repair his motorcycle for what lay ahead. The next day, at the agreed 5 am, we met at the Bijapur bus stop (there was no network except BSNL in Bastar in 2015), and set off.

He was young, but he was my first teacher in Bastar. He taught me the dangers of relieving yourself on the sides of a freshly laid road, because that's where an IED would be. He taught me to stand up on the back of a bike to ensure that your muscles don't spasm under duress.

We navigated paved roads, and then unpaved roads, and then no roads. Carried the motorcycle across streams. Waded through mud. He told me how to navigate a complicated world of hostile police, hostile Maoists, and beleaguered people.



DIPANKAR GHOSE IS A WHT SCHOLAR FROM THE UNIVERSITY OF OXFORD. HE IS PRESENTLY THE DEPUTY NATIONAL EDITOR AT HINDUSTAN TIMES. IN 2015, HE MET MUKESH WHILE COVERING A STORY IN BASTAR. IMAGE COURTESY: WEIDENFELD-HOFFMANN TRUST, UNIVERSITY OF OXFORD

It was an important story, and the state took note. But the byline said my name, not his. Mukesh did this over and over again. Not just for me, but for many others. It was on his back that the stories of Bijapur, of lives lived in conflict, were ever told.

For me, Mukesh was the personification of bravery. I'm not going to pretend that in a universe where media organisations he worked for didn't even pay for his petrol let alone a stable salary, sustenance wasn't a problem, and therefore some wires weren't crossed.

But Mukesh loved journalism with a passion. When he was with you, nothing was impossible. He was always compassionate to people he reported on, always empathetic. He was rooted in Bastar, but not limited by it.

After a decade of jumping from one channel to the other, he realised organisations would never truly value its ground reporters in the region. He recognized the power of technology, and started Bastar Junction, a YouTube channel that at last count has 162K followers.

Go to YouTube now and watch his videos, and you will find more journalism than screaming television studios can ever offer. He reported from spots of attacks, crossed forests and mountains to get to victims of violence, reported from police camps, and from Naxal camps.

Journalism in Bastar has risks, and he bore them all. Getting to a spot is more physically arduous, more dangerous than most can imagine. Maoists threatened his life several times; the state threatened him when he exposed excess.

He was often bullied by his own Bijapur fraternity for helping "national journalists" but he never, ever wavered. It was him, and my other dear friend Ganesh Mishra, who risked their lives and went deep into the forests to rescue a CRPF Jawan abducted by Maoists.

But Bastar claimed him. On December 24, Mukesh reported on a shoddily built road in Bijapur--an obvious case of corruption. The story caused an enquiry. A week later, Mukesh was found dead, buried inside a septic tank in the home of the contractor that built that road.

The last time I met him was during the Chhattisgarh elections, when I spent the day with him and Ganesh Mishra. We reported, talked and laughed for hours. And then Mukesh took me home because he had cooked some lunch for me himself.

We laughed and lamented my distance from Bastar, and friends like the two of them. His last message to me, in October, had the words "Pata nahi kab mulakat hogi, par mulakat ka intezaar humesha rahega." I told him, "jald hogi mulakat."

How does one begin to remember him? As a journalist? As a bridge to Bastar? As the voice of those that would never be heard otherwise? Remember him as them all. To me, he was Mukesh Chandrakar, my friend, my brother. Go well, bhai. Mulaqaat ka humesha intezaar rahega.

Dipankar Ghose is a WHT Scholar from the University of Oxford. He is presently the Deputy National Editor at Hindustan Times, and previously worked with the Indian Express. He is a three time Ramnath Goenka Awardee, & received the Prem Bhatia Award for Journalism in 2020.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR



Dipankar Ghose

CONTRIBUTOR

Dipankar Ghose is a WHT Scholar from the University of Oxford. He is presently the Deputy National Editor at Hindustan Times, and previously worked with the Indian Express. He is a three time Ramnath Goenka Awardee, & received the Prem Bhatia Award for Journalism in 2020.

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time.

READER-SUPPORTED JOURNALISM



Read this article online



Support via Razorpay



Read the magazine



The Newsstand

SOURCES & REFERENCES

^[1] 18 part eulogy